

485–443 MYA

ORDOVICIAN

The first fish appeared, such as the scaly, jawless *Astraspis*. Molluscs and corals dominated the oceans. The period ended with mass extinctions.



SPONGE



TRILOBITE



BRACHIOPOD (SHELL)



FALSE MUSSEL



HALLUCIGENIA



SEA MAT



ASTRASPI (FISH)

443–419 MYA

SILURIAN

Plants, such as the leafless *Cooksonia*, grew on land. In the seas, there were more fish, and spiny animals called echinoderms thrived. Early scorpions may have left the oceans for land.



COOKSONIA (PLANT)



ECHINODERM



CORAL



LOGANELIA (FISH)

419–358 MYA

DEVONIAN

Many new types of fish evolved, such as the *Tiktaalik*. This was a lobe-finned fish belonging to the group from which the amphibians eventually evolved.



SOLICLYMENIA (AMMONITE)



STENACANTHUS (SHARK)



TIKTAALIK (FISH)



DISCALIS (PLANT)

298–252 MYA

PERMIAN

The hot, dry conditions of this period favoured reptiles, such as *Dimetrodon*. At the end of this period a catastrophic mass extinction wiped out 70 per cent of land species and 90 per cent of marine life.



EOTHYRIS (REPTILE)



ECHINODERM



CORAL



SPINIOAEQUALIS (REPTILE)



OPHIACODON (REPTILE)

CARBONIFEROUS

As lush swamp forests grew, life on Earth flourished. Reptiles such as *Spinioaequalis* and *Ophiacodon* evolved.



ODONTOPTERIS (FERN)



CLUB MOSS



AMPHIBAMUS (AMPHIBIAN)



COCKROACH

65–23 MYA

PALEOGENE

With the dinosaurs extinct, mammals and birds evolved rapidly. Most of the main groups of mammals had their beginnings in this period.



AMMONITE



OSMUNDA (FERN)



ROTULARIA (WORMS)



CHAMA AND XENOPHORA (MOLLUSCS)



ICARONYCTERIS (BAT)



UINTATHERIUM (MAMMAL)

23–2 MYA

NEOGENE

The first humans, or hominins, evolved in this era. More modern types of mammals, such as kangaroos and giraffes, appeared.



THYLACOSMILUS (MAMMAL)



CARCHARODON (SHARK)

2 MYA–PRESENT DAY

QUATERNARY

Ice ages with warmer phases in between have dominated the last two million years. Modern humans (*Homo sapiens*) arose in eastern Africa and spread across the world.



NEPTUNEA (SEA SNAIL)



MAMMOTH



HUMAN ANCESTOR